

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Fall Series 6

Sacred Earth, Sacred Soul

Reawakening to What Our Souls Already Know

11 October 2026



Hot Springs: Yavapai Co. Arizona, Maxfield Parrish, 1902

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions...

We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time.

Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on SLANE and OLD HUNDREDTH

ST. DENIO (William H. Bates) and Improvisation

Pastorale (Cécile Chaminade)

VATER UNSER IM HIMMELREICH (Samuel Scheidt)

Meditation on LACQUIPARLE

Vorspiel in D Major (Johann Christian Heinrich Rinck) and Improvisation

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Words of Gathering

Rev. Fregin, Emily Kang & Gavin Gregorio

Fountain of life...

Pulse of life...

Breath of life...

Earth is filled with the presentness of God.

A planet filled with the presence of God
*a living green blue planet,
people from every corner of creation,
the vast reaches of space above us,
and the rocks and hills and wonders of the wild.*

Together this day,
let us sense and feel the face of God in all creation.

*Together this day,
let us celebrate the life-giving
breath of our God.*

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Creator God You Gave Us Life

OLD HUNDRETH

Creator God, you gave us life,
Your image formed within our souls,
Yet through the mist of time and space,
We search for that which makes us whole.

In every flow'r and every tree,
We see your great diversity,
Yet greater still we see your love,
Expressed in our humanity.

When with our hearts,
Our hands our minds,
We share our gifts with all the world,
Our spirits soar beyond the veil,
To touch the very face of God.

Through hands that paint majestic skies,
And voices chanting melody,
With words that reach beyond the page,
We comprehend your mystery.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Fregin

God of love, show us our place in this world
as channels of your love
for all the creatures of this earth -
for not one of us is forgotten in your sight.

Enlighten those who possess power and money
that they may avoid indifference,
that they may love the common good,
advance the weak,
and care for this world
in which we live.
The poor, the oppressed, and the earth
are crying out.

So we ask, Good and Gracious God, seize us with your power,
with your beautiful darkness, with your amazing light,
and help us to protect all life,
with all that we have and all that we are
as we work for your kin-dom
of justice, peace, love, and beauty.

-adapted from the Pope's Encyclical, 2015

Amen and Amen.

***Introit**

Iona Alleluia TRADITIONAL CELTIC FROM THE ISLAND OF IONA

Frank Hobbs, *Soloist*, Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*

***The Lord's Prayer**

Emily Kang & Gavin Gregorio

*Our [God], who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kingdom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power, and the glory,*

*forever.
Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Fregin

For the gift of this new day
for waking again from the dreams of the night
for our bodies strengthened and our minds renewed
Thanks be to you, O God.

You are the stillness of the night,
you are the genesis of the morning
you are the dew of new creation.

*Let there be peace in the human soul
let there be waking to new consciousness*

In the life of the world this day
and in our hearts
let there be fresh hope for peace.

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition
From the Gospel of John

Emily Kang & Gavin Gregorio

This is the Gospel of Love and Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Fregin

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Creator Spirit,
we give thanks that your life-giving Presence
has been active in our universe for all the billions of years
that have passed since the first moments of its existence.

Working within and with what was there,
your Presence came to visible expression
in the formation of stars
and galaxies
and planets.

Rocks and grasses,
water and soil,
all living things, including us,
came to life with a conscious
awareness and appreciation
of your Presence.

Help us on this day
to marvel at this life,
as we continue to embrace
this Sacred Earth we call home.

*Help us on this day
to celebrate the Source of all that is
and of all that shall be. Amen and Amen!* [mmorwood / adapt]

Meditation Anthem

TRADITIONAL AFRICAN-AMERICAN SPIRITUAL arr. MOSES HOGAN

This Little Light of Mine

Lorenzo Zapata, *Soloist*, Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*

Sermon

Reawakening to What Our Souls Already Know

Rev. Michael Lehman

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

We are drawn together by the Wisdom of the universe,
nature's intelligence,
embodied in Jesus
and present in all souls
who gather at Wisdom's table.

*We gather to receive grace to give up our foolish ways,
to walk in Wisdom's light,
to delight in creation and in one another,
as the Holy One delights in us.*

May we open the gates of our souls, that Wisdom may enter,
making us friends of God and one another.

*We open in this time to the
transforming power of the Spirit.*

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Emily Kang

Each morning brings us a newness
that we but need to step into.
It can wash us,
lift us,
heal us,
hold us
just as each of us has need.

As we give from our financial resources this morning,
to continue the work of this church
may we be open to the power that lies within us.
May we be full with a confidence in our strength.
May we move from empty routines
to the fullness of life
that we might live God's dream.

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

Art Thou Troubled?

G. F. HANDEL

Tiffany Ho, *Soprano*, Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organ*

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Offering Prayer**

Gavin Gregorio

Holy One, as we give our offerings
may our eyes be open
to see you in all the colors of creation
as you use our generosity to awaken us
to a new sense of awe and wonder.

May we know you, O God, as the sacred presence that is real to us.
May we know you, O God, as the one who is the source of inspiration
and courage as you keep calling us forward
to share your dream for our world.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen.

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman & Rev. Fregin

Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

May the God you see in all the colors of creation
awaken in you a sense of awe and wonder.
May the God who is a sacred presence be real to you.
May the God who is the source of inspiration and courage
keep calling you forward.
May your God go with you and bless you.
May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

Peace, Be Still

SHAWN KIRCHNER

*Peace, be still, and know that I am God. Peace, be still, and know that I am
Peace, be still, and know. Peace, be still. Peace, be. Peace, peace, peace.*

***Hymn for the Journey**

Wake Now My Senses

SLANE

Wake now my senses, and hear the Earth call,
Feel the deep power of being in all,
Keep with the web of creation your vow,
Giving, receiving, as love shows us how.

Wake now my reason, reach out for the new,
Join with each trav'ler who quests for the true,
Honor the beauty and wisdom of time,
Transcend our limits and touch the sublime.

Wake now my vision, the dream we hold dear,
Brighten our pathway with radiance here,
Journey together with all who will share,
Love for the planet transformed by our care.

--lyrics Mikelson

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Short Prelude in D minor (Ascribed to J.S. Bach)

Inside The Music

"When I stood on the rocks of Iona, Scotland, I felt a deep and immediate connection to my ancestors and the breath and matter that formed them. Though I am not of Indigenous Celtic descent, standing on rocks over 3 billion years old that had survived erosion, climate change, billions of years of tectonic shifting, and that which stood through the forcible removal and genocide of the Indigenous people on those lands reawakened and reconnected me with a fully embodied knowledge of my own ancestry whose bodies experienced genocide in a different land. It is this *deep knowing* of which the Celts speak and it poured through my body without my even asking. Today, we begin Part II of our Fall Series,

Sacred Earth, Sacred Soul, where we explore the Celtic theology of Original Goodness: a direct resistance of the dominant theology of the imperial church that insisted our nature at birth was corrupt and inherently sinful. Original Goodness tells us that which we already deeply know: that at our birth we are a reflection of the Divine themselves — a mirrored image of the soul of God.

To start this journey, we sing an *Alleluia* from this island which birthed Celtic theology. A melody that seems as though it has always been flowing, inviting us to sing it during our time, and after which it will keep flowing. When I was in Iona and our guide, the Celtic theologian John Phillip Newell, taught us this melody, a wave of excitement passed through me as I realized I had known the tune my entire life. I hadn't known of its ancient Celtic origins, but somehow, it had found its way into the life of a Mediterranean girl from Boston. And isn't music like that? It can remind us of our interconnectedness and wholeness, of the goodness that is innate within us, which connects us over time and place.

Tiffany sings and Christoph plays of this connection within and throughout us in Handel's melody, *Art Thou Troubled? Music will calm thee. Art thou weary? Rest shall be thine*. And Lorenzo and the Cathedral Choir also encourage our inner lights shining through Moses Hogan's arrangement of the well-loved African-American spiritual *This Little Light of Mine*. For in the theology of the Indigenous Celts we are reminded of that inner light—present at our birth—meant to be shared as a beacon for ourselves and others. In closing, we sing the Peace Canon of Los Angeles musician and friend Shawn Kirchner, where we sing individually and collectively, *Be Still and Know that I am Peace.*" ~ Dr. Ianthe Marini